



Communication Skills

RESOURCE PERSON: AQSA RIAZ

LECTURE: 01

Learning Objectives

- ▶ Define communication and describe communication as a process.
- ▶ Identify and describe the eight essential components of communication.
- ▶ Identify and describe levels of communication.

Cycle of Communication



What is communication?

The root of the word “communication” in Latin is *communicare*, which means to share, or to make common (Weekley, 1967). Communication is defined as the process of understanding and sharing meaning .

At the center of our study of communication, is the relationship that involves interaction between participants.

Importance

Communication is all around us, from the moment we wake and switch on the radio, read the newspaper, pass the advertising boards on the way to work and listen to the train announcements. During our working day, communication enables tasks to be completed diligently and ultimately makes us, and the company, more professional. In business, communication skills are highly valued. Leaders with ineffective communication skills can often be the root cause of productivity-related issues.

In our daily life, communication helps us build relationships by allowing us to share our experiences, and needs, and helps us connect to others. It's the essence of life, allowing us to express feelings, pass on information and share thoughts. We all need to communicate.

Components

In order to better understand the communication process, we can break it down into a series of eight essential components:

- ▶ Source
- ▶ Message
- ▶ Channel
- ▶ Receiver
- ▶ Feedback
- ▶ Environment
- ▶ Context
- ▶ Interference

► Source:

The source imagines, creates, and sends the message. In a public speaking situation, the source is the person giving the speech. He or she conveys the message by sharing new information with the audience. The speaker also conveys a message through his or her tone of voice, body language, and choice of clothing. The speaker begins by first determining the message—what to say and how to say it. The second step involves encoding the message by choosing just the right order or the perfect words to convey the intended meaning. The third step is to present or send the information to the receiver or audience. Finally, by watching for the audience's reaction, the source perceives how well they received the message and responds with clarification or supporting information.

► **Message:**

“The message is the stimulus or meaning produced by the source for the receiver or audience.” (McLean, 2005) When you plan to give a speech or write a report, your message may seem to be only the words you choose that will convey your meaning. But that is just the beginning. The words are brought together with grammar and organization. You may choose to save your most important point for last. The message also consists of the way you say it—in a speech, with your tone of voice, your body language, and your appearance—and in a report, with your writing style, punctuation, and the headings and formatting you choose. In addition, part of the message may be the environment or context you present it in and the noise that might make your message hard to hear or see.

► Channel:

“The channel is the way in which a message or messages travel between source and receiver.” (McLean, 2005) For example, think of your television. How many channels do you have on your television? Each channel takes up some space, even in a digital world, in the cable or in the signal that brings the message of each channel to your home. Television combines an audio signal you hear with a visual signal you see. Together they convey the message to the receiver or audience.

Similarly, when you speak or write, you are using a channel to convey your message. Spoken channels include face-to-face conversations, speeches, telephone conversations and voice mail messages, radio, public address systems, and voice over Internet protocol (VoIP). Written channels include letters, memorandums, purchase orders, invoices, newspaper and magazine articles, blogs, e-mail, text messages, tweets, and so forth.

► **Receiver:**

“The receiver receives the message from the source, analyzing and interpreting the message in ways both intended and unintended by the source”

As a receiver you listen, see, touch, smell, and/or taste to receive a message. Your audience “sizes you up,” much as you might check them out long before you take the stage or open your mouth. The nonverbal responses of your listeners can serve as clues on how to adjust your opening. By imagining yourself in their place, you anticipate what you would look for if you were them. Just as a quarterback plans where the receiver will be in order to place the ball correctly, you too can recognize the interaction between source and receiver in a business communication context. All of this happens at the same time, illustrating why and how communication is always changing.

► **Feedback:**

When you respond to the source, intentionally or unintentionally, you are giving feedback. Feedback is composed of messages the receiver sends back to the source. Verbal or nonverbal, all these feedback signals allow the source to see how well, how accurately (or how poorly and inaccurately) the message was received. Feedback also provides an opportunity for the receiver or audience to ask for clarification, to agree or disagree, or to indicate that the source could make the message more interesting. As the amount of feedback increases, the accuracy of communication also increases

► **Environment:**

“The environment is the atmosphere, physical and psychological, where you send and receive messages.”

The environment can include the tables, chairs, lighting, and sound equipment that are in the room. The room itself is an example of the environment. The environment can also include factors like formal dress, that may indicate whether a discussion is open and caring or more professional and formal. People may be more likely to have an intimate conversation when they are physically close to each other, and less likely when they can only see each other from across the room

Context:

- ▶ “The context of the communication interaction involves the setting, scene, and expectations of the individuals involved.”

Context is all about what people expect from each other, and we often create those expectations out of environmental cues. Traditional gatherings like weddings or quinceañeras are often formal events. There is a time for quiet social greetings, a time for silence as the bride walks down the aisle, or the father may have the first dance with his daughter as she is transformed from a girl to womanhood in the eyes of her community. In either celebration there may come a time for rambunctious celebration and dancing. You may be called upon to give a toast, and the wedding or quinceañera context will influence your presentation, timing, and effectiveness.

► **Interference:**

Interference, also called noise, can come from any source. “Interference is anything that blocks or changes the source’s intended meaning of the message.” (McLean, 2005) For example, if you drove a car to work or school, chances are you were surrounded by noise. Car horns, billboards, or perhaps the radio in your car interrupted your thoughts, or your conversation with a passenger.

Interference can come from other sources, too. Perhaps you are hungry, and your attention to your current situation interferes with your ability to listen. Maybe the office is hot and stuffy. If you were a member of an audience listening to an executive speech, how could this impact your ability to listen and participate?

Levels of Communication

- ▶ **Intrapersonal communication** is communication with oneself and occurs only inside our heads.
- ▶ **Interpersonal communication** is communication between people whose lives mutually influence one another and typically occurs in dyads, which means in pairs.
- ▶ **Group communication** occurs when three or more people communicate to achieve a shared goal.
- ▶ **Public communication** is sender focused and typically occurs when one person conveys information to an audience.
- ▶ **Mass communication** occurs when messages are sent to large audiences using print or electronic media.